Appreciative Inquiry and Ethical Leadership: Cultivating Light in Organizational Culture

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Introduction

Leadership within public service organizations carries a profound ethical responsibility—not only to fulfill administrative duties but also to shape a culture that inspires trust, accountability, and positive engagement. As an Executive Director of a nonprofit or governmental agency, the ability to foster ethical consciousness is paramount. Appreciative Inquiry (AI), as developed by Barrett and Fry (2008), provides a transformative approach to leadership by emphasizing organizational strengths and values. Rather than focusing solely on correcting dysfunction, AI seeks to elevate what is already working well. This strength-based perspective is especially effective when aligned with the ethical standards outlined in Cooper's (2006) Components of Responsible Conduct and Johnson's (2018) metaphor of "casting light" instead of shadows in leadership.

This paper explores how the principles and practices of Appreciative Inquiry support ethical leadership and help advance Cooper's framework for responsible administration. Drawing from Fry's work and five Appreciative Inquiry articles cited in the syllabus, the discussion will focus on how leaders can cultivate a culture rooted in ethical behavior, transparency, and inclusion. Ultimately, this paper aims to show how AI can be a powerful tool in building ethical organizations that reflect light in every dimension of their leadership and operations.

Casting Light Instead of Shadows: Johnson and Cooper's Ethical Foundations

In *Meeting the Ethical Challenges of Leadership*, Johnson (2018) introduces the metaphor of "casting light or shadow" to describe the moral influence of leaders. Leaders who cast light create environments of trust, integrity, and ethical growth; those who cast shadows foster fear, secrecy, and self-interest. This duality challenges leaders to reflect on how their behaviors, decisions, and values affect those around them. Johnson's framework is not simply a poetic metaphor—it is a call for ethical self-awareness and intentionality in leadership.

Complementing this idea, Cooper (2006) presents the Components of Responsible Conduct, which provide a practical ethical blueprint for public administrators. His model emphasizes key principles such as respect for the law, transparency, responsiveness, and the duty to serve the public interest. These components are not stand-alone values but interconnected elements that guide behavior and decision-making in complex organizational settings.

When considered together, Johnson's metaphor and Cooper's components underscore a leader's dual responsibility: to model ethical behavior and to cultivate a culture that supports it. Appreciative Inquiry, with its focus on positive change and shared vision, aligns well with these responsibilities by encouraging ethical dialogue, celebrating integrity, and reinforcing organizational values.

Appreciative Inquiry: A Framework for Positive Ethical Leadership

Appreciative Inquiry (AI), as outlined by Barrett and Fry (2008), offers a dynamic alternative to traditional problem-solving approaches in organizational development. Rather than identifying what is broken, AI focuses on what gives life to an organization—its values, successes, and aspirations. The process is rooted in the belief that inquiry into human systems should begin with appreciation, not deficit. This foundation directly supports Johnson's (2018) metaphor of casting light, as it encourages organizations to illuminate their best selves rather than dwell in shadows of dysfunction.

In Chapters 1 and 2, Fry introduces the philosophical underpinnings of AI, emphasizing the importance of narrative, imagination, and co-creation in shaping organizational culture. These early chapters establish AI as a relational and reflective process, where dialogue serves as a vehicle for shared meaning and ethical visioning. AI is not a neutral method—it is inherently value-driven and ethical in its pursuit of what is good and life-affirming within organizations.

From Cooper's (2006) perspective, this strength-based approach resonates with the principles of responsible conduct. By focusing on shared values, transparency, and inclusive dialogue, AI fosters a culture of responsiveness and integrity. For example, in public service settings where ethical breaches may erode trust, the AI model offers a path to rebuild confidence by engaging staff and stakeholders in co-authoring ethical narratives that uplift rather than punish.

Building Ethical Capacity: Chapters 3–10 of Fry's Appreciative Inquiry

Chapters 3 and 4 of Barrett and Fry's (2008) work explore the power of language and the role of generative questions. Shifting questions from "What went wrong?" to "When were we at our best?" creates a constructive tone that strengthens ethical commitment. Cooper (2006) supports this kind of ethical responsiveness, and Johnson (2018) reinforces that it's through reflection and transparency that leaders cast light.

Chapters 5 and 6 introduce the 4-D Cycle—Discovery, Dream, Design, and Destiny—as a framework for fostering ethical imagination and shared leadership. These steps guide teams through reflection on strengths, envisioning ethical futures, and co-creating processes that reinforce integrity. Cooper's values, especially inclusion and accountability, come to life through this participatory model.

Chapters 7 and 8 emphasize collaborative design and collective responsibility. They stress that ethical systems must be built with the people who live within them. Embedding ethical values into organizational policies through employee involvement echoes Cooper's concept of internalizing ethical norms and reinforces Johnson's advocacy for authenticity in leadership.

Chapters 9 and 10 focus on sustaining change through storytelling and learning. AI encourages leaders to continuously highlight stories of ethical success and encourage others to do the same. This ongoing dialogue forms the backbone of ethical resilience and aligns with Cooper's principle of continuous improvement.

Practical Application: Creating a Culture of Light in My Organization

As an Executive Director, I would use Appreciative Inquiry to design an ethical framework rooted in participation, reflection, and collective growth. My approach would begin with hosting a series of Discovery sessions where staff reflect on past ethical successes and highlight examples of excellence in teamwork, transparency, or community engagement. These sessions would be cross-functional and inclusive to ensure all voices are heard.

The next step would be the Dream phase, where teams imagine the future of the organization through an ethical lens. Staff would co-develop ethical aspirations that reflect our values and create a shared vision of a high-trust culture. These conversations would guide the Design phase, during which we would collaboratively update our code of ethics, develop peer-recognition systems, and create training modules that reflect the strengths already present within the team.

The Destiny phase would focus on implementation and sustainability. Ethical storytelling would be woven into staff meetings and orientation sessions. Quarterly reflection groups would be introduced to help staff talk through ethical challenges in a safe, constructive setting. These efforts would help normalize conversations about ethics and encourage self-regulation and peer accountability.

This Appreciative Inquiry-driven model does more than meet compliance requirements—it creates a living ethical culture where casting light becomes a daily practice. Employees would not only understand the organization's values, they would see themselves as co-authors and guardians of those values.

Conclusion

In this paper, I explored how Appreciative Inquiry can serve as both a leadership framework and an ethical strategy for shaping organizational culture. AI challenges leaders like me to focus not just on fixing problems, but on amplifying what already works—our values, our stories, and our strengths. By engaging employees in co-creating ethical systems and encouraging meaningful reflection, I believe leaders can shape cultures that inspire trust, inclusion, and accountability.

What stood out most to me in this process is how closely AI aligns with Cooper's (2006) Components of Responsible Conduct and Johnson's (2018) idea of casting light instead of shadows. These frameworks are not just theoretical—they are practical tools I can apply in my future leadership. Ethical transformation doesn't begin with policies alone; it begins with people, conversations, and the willingness to lead with humility and hope.

I want to be the kind of leader who sets that tone—who invites collaboration, celebrates ethical success, and normalizes ethical conversations in the workplace. Through AI, I've found a model that reinforces the kind of leadership I value: inclusive, responsive, and transparent. Ultimately, my goal is to foster a culture where light becomes not just a metaphor, but a mindset—shared, sustained, and practiced every day.

References

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